Peres was born Szymon Perski in a village in eastern Poland (now part of Belarus). His family emigrated to Palestine in the 1930s, when he was eleven. It was a fateful decision: his relatives who stayed behind were killed during the Holocaust, many of them burned alive in the town synagogue. “The doors were locked from the outside and the wooden structure was torched,” he said in 2010 during a speech to the German parliament. “And the only remains of the whole community were embers.”

He quickly threw himself into junior politics, rising through the ranks of the Labor movement and attracting the attention of David Ben-Gurion. He joined the Haganah, the main pre-state militia, but never saw combat. Instead he was tasked with procuring weapons. His closeness to Ben-Gurion led to a series of lofty assignments: first head of the Israeli navy, then the director of the defense ministry’s mission in New York. In 1952, four years after Israel declared independence—when Peres was just twenty-nine—he was named deputy director-general of the defense ministry.

Despite the mythology of Peres the peacemaker, his work at the defense ministry was his most important legacy. Ben-Gurion tasked him with acquiring a nuclear weapon, a doomsday device that would shield the tiny, vulnerable state. Peres recruited a batch of young physicists to work at two nuclear research centers, at Soreq and Dimona, and funded the project with millions of dollars donated by wealthy Jews who wanted to contribute to Israel’s survival.

Then he flew to Paris. The Egyptian president, Gamal Abdel Nasser, had just nationalized the Suez Canal. Britain and France feared that Nasser would restrict access to the waterway, a vital conduit for oil supplies, and started planning an invasion. Israel offered to help. It demanded a few things in return—one of which was France’s help in building a research reactor. The Suez crisis was a diplomatic disaster for the European powers, but it paid dividends for Israel. By the end of the decade, hundreds of French engineers were working in the Negev to build what was officially called a “textile plant”, the genesis of a nuclear program that has produced an estimated 100–200 warheads. (Israel does not acknowledge its nuclear arsenal under a policy of “strategic ambiguity.” But it came close to discarding that policy after Peres died: the reclusive atomic energy commission issued a rare public statement thanking him for his “great contributions to building up the security of the state of Israel.”)